



The weathered landscape of central Anatolia, a Byzantine territory that suffered repeated raids from Arab forces in the 7th century.

THE SPLIT BETWEEN SUNNI AND SHIITE MUSLIMS was the outcome of fierce disagreement over how succession to the caliphate ought to be decided; either by selection (as in the case of the first three caliphs) or by hereditary descent. Caliph Uthman (r. 644–56) had promoted members of his own clan, the **Umayyads**. He was assassinated in 656 by Egyptian soldiers, nursing grievances over their lower status. **Ali Ibn Abi Talib** became the **fourth caliph**. As Muhammad's cousin and son-in-law—next in line by descent—Ali enjoyed unique status in the Islamic world, but he faced many challenges. At the **Battle of the Camel** in 656 Ali overcame a revolt by the prophet's widow A'isha and her allies, opposing his inclusive policies. In 657, the Umayyad emir of Syria, **Mu'awiya**, asserted his claim on the caliphate; Ali was also challenged by the Kharijis, a sect that objected to the application of the hereditary principle. In 661, **Ali was murdered** by a Khariji, opening the way for **Mu'awiya to declare himself caliph**, instituting the Arab Umayyad dynasty. Ali's supporters formed a party of their own, which evolved into a distinctive branch of Islam, the **Shiites**, in opposition to the Sunni. Emperor Constans II attempted to reestablish



Expansion under the caliphate

The rapid Arab expansion continued throughout the latter half of the 7th century. Islamic armies pushed into Central Asia and North Africa, bringing them within striking distance of Spain.

KEY

- Muslim lands by 656
- Byzantine Empire c.610
- Sasanian Empire c.610
- Frankish Kingdoms c.610

Byzantine claims to Italy by relocating his court to Rome in 663, but raids deep into Anatolia (modern-day Turkey) by Arab

forces led to a collapse in his authority; in 668, he was assassinated and **Constantine IV** took the throne. **Arab incursions** into

Anatolia continued and by 670 they had reached the Byzantine capital, Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul), launching the **first siege on the city**, which would last until 677.

The **Unified Silla kingdom** in Korea brought to an end the long Three Kingdoms period, with the help of **Tang China**. In 660 the Tang destroyed the kingdom of Paekche, while in 668 Silla and Tang forces combined to overcome Koguryo, thus bringing all of the Korean Peninsula under Silla control.



Stoneware bird

This gray stoneware incense burner dates from the Silla kingdom, which was on the verge of becoming the dominant power during Korea's late Three Kingdoms period.



A modern-day depiction of the Battle of Karbala; al-Husayn's death is commemorated in the annual Shiite ritual of the ashura.

THE MAYA CITY-STATE OF TIKAL BEGAN ITS RESURGENCE after a century-long period of political and cultural domination by neighboring city-states known as the Tikal hiatus, which had been marked by an absence of inscriptions in the city's petroglyphic record. An inscription dated to 672 records a military campaign against the **rival city-state of Dos Pilas**, and in the following decades Tikal restored its position among the Maya of the Late Classic period (600–900). The city's rulers engaged in a construction programme to match their political ambitions, **building many impressive structures** including massive pyramids, ball

courts, causeways, observatories, and palaces.

The Arab forces besieging the city of Constantinople (see 670) were unable to breach its massive walls and were eventually beaten off with the use of a new **Byzantine secret weapon**—“Greek fire” (see 711–20). Its deployment may also have helped destroy the Arab fleet at the Battle of Syllaeum in 677, forcing the **caliphate to agree a 30-year truce**. The truce bought breathing space for the embattled Byzantine Empire, struggling to hold back the Bulgars, who established the **First Bulgarian Empire** in 681 on conquered Byzantine territory north of the Balkan mountains.



ARAB CONQUESTS

Having consolidated their conquests of Persia and Byzantine North Africa, Arab armies pressed on eastward and westward. In Central Asia, Arab forces crossed the Oxus River in 667 and continued to advance to within range of the Silk Road kingdom of Bukhara. In Africa, they crushed the Berber kingdoms, reaching Tangiers in 683.

